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**Implications of Names in *The Name of the Wind* by
Patrick Rothfuss**

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Podpis

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ABSTRACT

The objective of this thesis is a thorough analysis of names in the novel *The Name of the Wind* by Patrick Rothfuss. The attention is paid to the layers of implications that different kinds of names can carry, as well as to the means of introducing the names in narrative. Other aspect of names that are taken into consideration are the motivation, meaning, and power behind them, and their functions in the story.

ANOTÁCIA

Zámerom tejto práce je podrobná analýza mien v románe *Meno Vetra* od Patricka Rothfussa. Pozornosť sa venuje vrstvám náznakov ktoré môžu rôzne druhy mien nosiť, rovnako ako spôsobu ktorým sú mená v naratívne uvedené. Ostatné aspekty mien ktoré budeme brať v úvahu sú motivácia, význam a sila mien a ich funkcie v príbehu.

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Introduction

The importance of names is noted in the title of the novel *The Name of the Wind*, and then again in its text, explicitly by characters, and implicitly by the number of names and the care with which they were chosen and weaved into the story. They are crucial for the plot, an inseparable part of narrative. The reason I have chosen this novel are these names and the many intricate layers they contain, the implications they offer to the reader to decode.

The Name of the Wind is a young adult fantasy novel taking place in a fictional world. While a story of a hero who must find his place in the world is nothing unusual in this genre, the way the protagonist in *The Name of the Wind*, Kvothe, earns his names, the number of them and the attention he pays to them when he narrates his story, is quite extraordinary. Because of this, I was curious what kind of information can be hidden in names when they are used so excessively, how much they can hide or imply, and how do they help to create a believable, full, and exciting story. My aim is to define the functions of names in *The Name of the Wind* and uncover the hidden implications in them.

1 Names and naming in fiction

Names have an important role in fiction, often carry hidden meanings, power, or just stand out, to make a character memorable. Therefore, authors devote a lot of attention to naming and carefully weave the names of people, places and things into the canopy of their fictional world, creating links for the reader to better navigate the text and to connect to the story. As Anderson said: “We all have connections to things, and those relationships come to life when we name names.”(27) When something is given a name, it seems more real, tangible. It is no coincidence that the novels that are discussed here, the Earthsea cycle by Le Guin and *The Name of the Wind*,¹ mention similar creation stories, where “at the beginning” a deity named all things and they came to existence. What is more, the chosen novels pay great attention to the topic of names – describe acquisition of a new name (e.g. in a ritual), carefully introduce apt names that communicate messages about the bearer, or ponder over the hidden power of names and their use.

The core question that stands in the centre of this research is: What are the implications of bearing a certain name? Indeed, what can be a motivation behind using a specific name in particular context? Many more sub-questions arise in connection to the primary one. What if a character bears several names, as is true for the main protagonist of *The Wind*, or none at all? What kind of information or messages can a name carry?

Hopefully, this work can shed some light on these questions. The initial chapter of theoretical section firstly opens the topic of names and lists the points of view we will consider in the analysis of names. Secondly, it introduces literary discipline that researches the connection of names and characters – literary onomastics. Thirdly, it discusses aborigine stories and naming practices of indigenous people Vula’a, who, in their names, connect not only a name and a bearer, but name, person (or place), and history. Names in Vula’a stories could be considered a bridge between the reality and fantastic, as they carry in them the naming traditions, but in the stories they acquire magical dimensions and display the hidden power.

1 *The Name of the Wind* will be further referenced only as *The Wind*

The core of the first chapter is then devoted to truly fantastic and offers the outline of treatment of names in contemporary young adult fiction. Chosen works include *Earthsea* cycle by Ursula K. Le Guin, and *Harry Potter* series by J.K. Rowling. Both authors are widely known and their novels each assume original approach to names.

The second chapter offers an overview of *The Wind* as a work of fiction, its synopsis, structure, and treatment of “true names.”²

1.1 Introduction to the name problematic

Names can be looked at as a part of a language they were formed in: they carry information, the traces such as the rules of pronunciation, gender etc. in them. (No need to tell the reader that Jake mentioned below is a boy.) They can be composed from figures of speech/metaphorical connections/pictures characteristic of the language – such as tropes and schemes that Rowling used in the names from H.P.: *Luna Lovegood* or *Dedalus Diggle* (Nilsen 65). English is no stranger to alliteration, which was already used in *Beowulf*. In both cases they have aesthetic function and show the author’s skill and language-play. Language creativity is also part of other languages, as will be shown later, in connection to people Vula’a, who record history and humour into their names. (Van Heekeren 169-184)

While tropes and schemes say something about the author’s style, they also hide meaning, so it is not possible to omit this point of view. For example, while naming magical objects, Rowling often uses conspicuous names based on oxymorons, and in doing so hints the object is magical to the reader sooner than the purpose of the thing in question is explained. (Nilsen 61-2)

Another way to look at names is to take them as inseparable parts of narrative. With the exception of experimental pieces, standard fantasy (and that is the genre we will discuss) makes use of them, even needs them for reference. Hemingway, in his short story ‘Cat in the rain,’ is able to express what he intends almost without proper names. (The only mentioned proper name *George*, the husband, appears at the end.)

2 Understand the “true name” as an embodiment of a thing or a person themselves; further discussed in Le Guin’s work below.

Nevertheless, even Hemingway cannot avoid referring to his characters in some way – e.g. using a noun phrase “the American wife” or “Italians”.(1-2) Names are not in the centre of his attention, and George’s name is the proof, as it says almost nothing about the character, except that he bears a common American name.

Yet another question that opens before us is this: how a reader perceives the implications of names that the author leaves in the text for him or her to interpret? How can we know that *Seth* and *Jake* in following excerpt from *The Name of the Wind* are just minor background characters with no special abilities, while *Hali*ax in the example further down catches our attention? Let us forget that Seth is described as ‘the old farmer’(Rothfuss 130); he could be an undercover magician, or a forest spirit who took human form, given the limitless possibilities of fiction:

‘I’m Seth, and this here is Jake. You might want to be sittin’ down, a bad bump could tip ye over the side.’ I sat on one of the bags, tense for no good reason, not knowing what to expect.(Rothfuss 130)

Indeed, Seth and Jake get only two pages from the whole six hundred and sixty-two pages long novel. Haliax, on the other hand, gets over a dozen pages:

‘*You are a tool in my hand,*’ the cool voice repeated. ‘*Say it.*’
Cinder’s jaw clenched angrily for a moment, then he convulsed and cried out, sounding more like a wounded animal than a man. ‘I am a tool in your hand,’ he gasped.
‘*Lord Hali*ax.’
‘I am a tool in your hand, Lord Haliax.’(Rothfuss 117)

Even without the context (and italicisation used for emphasis), Haliax’ name stands out, somehow the message that he is powerful is communicated to the reader. Haliax’ is the sole example of a name in the novel ending in ‘x’ letter. Indisputably, it is also not a regular English name,³ and draws our attention.

These two examples illustrate how vital it is to take context into consideration, when searching for the implications of names. Therefore we will rely on the context most of the time in the analytical part; and although our aim is to find the implications of names,

3 There exists a surname Halifax.(The Internet Surname database)

the messages they are able to communicate to the reader, we will not focus on the possible reader's response.

1.2 *Literary onomastics*

Literary onomastics is a discipline that investigates the “link between characters and their names”(Iliescu 144). Names are seen as the key constituents of the plot and carry “veiled meaning” for the reader to interpret in order to better understand the bearer of a name.(Iliescu 144) Writers use names not only to distinguish characters and to deliver hidden meaning; besides this, names also carry “significant semantic, pragmatic, connotative and symbolic value.”(Iliescu 146) Based on names, on condition they were chosen suitably and characterise a certain group, a reader can decode immediately the ethnic group of characters, the region or a time where the story takes place, etc.(Iliescu 147)

In our analysis, however, we will focus on more than just proper names of characters and what they say about the bearer. We will also look at the nature of “true names”, language play, associations names evoke, their functions and ways they are introduced in the text.

1.3 *Vula'a naming practices*

Vula'a people inhabit south-eastern part of Papua New Guinea and speak Hula. Their traditional stories/legends are called *rikwana*. Both in stories and in life the act of naming and names themselves are of great importance, as they connect the present and the past.(Van Heekeren 169) First, I will describe Vula'a naming practices concerning real places, people and things, and only then proceed to *rikwana*, in which the names have an important position.

1.3.1 *Vula'a names and their meanings*

Traditionally, Vula'a re-name places after something significant takes place there, the new name functioning as a “mnemonic condensation”, a way of “keeping past alive”

through the meaning of that particular name.(Heekeren 170) Van Heekeren introduces an example of a place name “Vagi Koko” which literally translates as “kill all” and speaks of a fierce battle that happened there.(Heekeren 170)

Similar custom applies to naming children; one of the tribe members explains: “Vula’a children are named according to the events and seasons that surround their birth,”(Van Heekeren 172-3) for example *Laa Kovau Lui*, the full name of Hula village founder, means “empty breast” and probably refers to the times of famine when he was born. (Heekeren 173)

Often a certain degree of playfulness plays a role in making up Vula’a first names, e.g. “good house” a literal translation from *Numa Nama*, or others with humorous English translations such as “cockroach,” or “talk”; Van Heekeren points out that these names are not “gendered” and siblings of different genders can be named by the same name. (172) Also, some names are passed down from the older to younger generations and carry in themselves the information about family relationships, e.g. *Laa* and *Leva*, names by which only the descendants of Hula village founders are named.(173) After analysing hundreds of first names, place names and names of things, she concludes that “Vula’a names always convey meaning, although the significance of any name is variable,”(172) and they often “serve as abbreviations”(181), speaking of the past and present of the bearer and their family relationships, as was mentioned above.

I will show later in the analysis that naming practices of Vula’a are in a way similar to naming in *The Name of the Wind*. I speak of the instances, when, as a result of important circumstances, the main protagonist Kvothe is given a new name (or, better said, yet another name, as he bears more than thirteen).

1.3.2 Rikwana

Now let us proceed to even more significant matter, the position of names in Vula’a stories that can partially shed some light on certain aspects of names in *The Name of the Wind*. Van Heekeren explains that *rikwana* mean more than just stories, they are inseparable part of Vula’a culture, messages left by the ancestors to cope with life difficulties, a connection to the past:

“For the Vula’a, the *rikwana*...reveal their participation with a range of entities; other humans, non-humans, ancestors, and places...they are about power as heat in the guise of magical actions, words, and songs.”(174)

The “heat” she refers to is *iavu*, “the centre of Vula’a cosmology”(176). It is “an unseen (yet deeply felt) power...[and] resonates with our ideas of the sacred, the magical, and the religious.”(176) Indeed, the characters in *rikwana* often resolve to actions that surpass the possibilities of a mere mortal, hence non-humans Van Heekeren mentions. Although no such a term as “magic” is mentioned in the stories, Vula’a use the word “sorcerer,” often with a negative connotation, as a sorcerer is a person who is able to deceive and (in some *rikwana*) harms people. “Heat,” however, is not to be strictly viewed as magical power; it is the connection with ancestors, the power of knowledge. (177)

To better understand Vula’a concept of magic, we need to look into *rikwana* called *Inauinau*, where a girl with the identical name is tricked by a group of sorcerers. They abandon her on a deserted island after hearing her plans for the following day. Here is an excerpt from one of Vula’a people narration:

She quickly got up...joined them unaware that they were sorcerers. She followed one of them who led her to the canoe and he said, ‘You went to sleep late so you can lie on the canoe while I paddle.’(Van Heekeren 177)

There is a superstition among Vula’a that warns people not to say their plans in the evening aloud, because a sorcerer might hear.(177) *Inauinau* from the story talks about her plans with her friends prior to being taken on an island. Van Heekeren stresses that “names do not only have a meaning attached, they engender the essence of the story.”(181)This view is in accordance with Illiescu’s, the names are central in these stories as well. *Rikwana* about Inauinau carries the morale or the “essence” of the story, in its title – *Inauinau* being derived from *inaina*, an “intimate talk”, or whisper; it also refers to incantation (sorcery).(Van Heekeren 179) This is also an example of mnemonic condensation mentioned above, a trait of Vula’a names – the title alone summarizes the story.

Following example illustrates how central to a story can a name be, and how use of

certain names can bring about power. The story, titled by Short⁴ simply as *rikwana 1* talks about power struggle of non-humans. Van Heekeren notes how “[t]he names of protagonists and the centrality of magical song are once again brought into focus.”(179)

This *rikwana* talks about a man *Maru*, whose actions in the story reveal him as a sorcerer, and his “trusted dog” *Roroma Kapina* (“dried-up base”). Other characters and beings bear a proper name in this story that aptly depicts their traits (either visual or personality), e.g. *Palagu Pokana Vovo*, meaning “many-mouthed spirit” (*palagu*=a spirit living in a swamp). In here, Van Heekeren looks back at the nature of Hula language and its ability to connect physical appearance and the essence or a thought attributed to a certain person or a thing:

“The poesis of the Hula language evokes the relationship between the physical form of the mangrove swamp and this particular *palagu* that is the essence of its habitat. Mangroves are many-mouthed places.”(181)

Both *Maru* and *Palagu* from the story chant a song, which, obviously, is an incantation, given what happens after singing. With the help of the song the latter finds out the hiding place of the former; *Maru* calls his dog across a great distance to help him on a hunt. There is more to this call than meets the eye, and Van Heekeren calls our attention to it, but before that, she explains that this “trusted dog” is also a powerful magical being.(181) “*Maru* controls the dog...we must recognise him as a man of knowledge and hence of *iavu*...the call is a magical song.”(181) This magical incantation (or song) brings the dog to the scene of the hunt:

Then *Roroma Kapina* heard him. In the house he jumped and jumped, he jumped out of the house...followed *Maru*’s scent...That dog said to *Maru*, ‘What place shall I bite?’ *Maru* said, ‘His throat.’ He bit the place (and) killed him.(Van Heekeren,180)

Van Heekeren points out, that this is the only instance in the story when *Maru* calls the dog by his name and he calls him with this song:

Roroma Kapina, Roroma Kapina,
In a far place, in a far place,

⁴ Van Heekeren used Short’s translations of collected stories; Short, Lillian - from unpublished M.A. Thesis: The Phonetics and Grammar of the Hula Language. 1963.

Is a big bush boar
Gnawing a gilimo tree?
Is he gnawing a pawa tree?
Gnawing it down.(Van Heekeren, 180)

What I find important in the *rikwana* about Maru and his dog *Roroma Kapina* is this: *Maru*, a sorcerer, speaks the name of a being, the dog, and the dog obeys – comes and does *Maru*’s bidding. The use of true names in *The Wind* follows the same pattern.

1.4 Names in Le Guin’s Earthsea cycle

Earthsea Cycle contains six books, starting with *A wizard of Earthsea*(1968) following by *The Tombs of Atuan* (1971) that were used as sources of reference below. The reason this series is used for a comparison with *The Name of the Wind* (2007) is that the books are categorised as young adult contemporary fictions, are set in a fictional world, and to a certain levels share the main topic. Simply put: the hero of *A wizard of Earthsea* is a young boy who, like hero of the latter novel, Kvothe, wants to learn magic.

1.4.1 Motivated names in Earthsea

Names, especially those of major characters, are often “motivated;” Robinson explains this motivation as “a mirror-like reflection between multiple associations of a name and the attributes of its designated character”(385). He further elaborates on these associations, first distinguishing the two kinds of names that appear in the Earthsea novels. The names that are known to everybody are called “use names” and characters are mostly addressed by these names. The opposite of use names are “true names” that are kept secret. A person is not given their true name until adolescence, and then it is known only to the person bearing the name and his or her namer i.e. the person that gave them the name, usually a sorcerer or a witch.(Robinson, 388)

As an example, Robinson chose the protagonist of the Earthsea series *Sparrowhawk*, which is the character’s “use name.” He is a sorcerer and this use name is given to him by other children, because of his affinity for birds. Robinson considers Sparrowhawk’s name to be “the one most transparently motivated...[and] *hawk*, *sparrow*, *arrow* and *harrow*”(389) are prominent lexical associations that the author incorporates into the

name. He goes even further, comparing the hero's traits (appearance and character) and the attributes that are usually connected with the previously listed associations. His comparison concludes that there are undeniable similarities between the two, e.g. "aquiline nose...bright, fierce eyes...being fierce, proud, or angry in temperament"(389), used for the description of Sparrowhawk corresponds with the description of sparrows or hawks.(Robinson, 389)

1.4.2 Naming ceremony and the power of knowing names

In contrast to *The Name of the Wind*, in *Earthsea*, a true name is given to a person during the "naming ceremony" (no such a thing occurs in *The Wind* as the true names are the nature of things).⁵ This happens after a person comes of age (around thirteen). Only the person who is given the true name and their namer are present, with some exceptions:

"The witch took from the boy is name, Duny, the name his mother had given him as a baby...Ogion, waiting, reached out his hand and clasping the boy's arm whispered to him his true name: Ged."(Le Guin 15)

In this quote is depicted a part of Sparrowhawk's naming ceremony scene, where three people are present – Sparrowhawk, who is given the name Ged, his namer, wizard Ogion, and the witch, Moss, who takes the boy's use name (Duny). This ceremony could be considered a ritual, given its symbolic nature; the named person strips and bathes in running water (a spring or a pond), then his or her new name is spoken formally, and they become adults.(Robinson 393-4)

While this "naming ceremony" aspect of names in *Earthsea* cycle is unlike any of *The Wind* key concepts of names, there is one strong resemblance concerning the true names. It is the "power" feature of knowing the names, a concept that is much older than the novels, a concept handed down from generation to generation, still traceable in aborigine tribes, as was shown above. In *A Wizard of Earthsea*, the power of knowing a true name is stressed by the narrator as follows: "Who knows a man's name, holds his life in keeping."(Le Guin, *A Wizard of Earthsea* 75) Through him, Le Guin reveals the world where everyone treats their true name with utmost care, revealing it only to the

⁵ The only exception is Tehlu's renaming ritual that resembles a kind of baptism ritual (158-9); for further explanation consult the analytical part

most trusted or closely related people. It is doubly true for sorcerers, who hold in their names greater power.(75)

This power of knowing a name is perceptible in actions and following response of beings in Le Guin's novel, e.g. when Sparrowhawk learns the true name of falcons and they obey his commands: "the wild falcons stooped down to him from the wind when he summoned them by name"(5). The scene is similar to the one when Kvothe's teacher Ben summons the wind at the beginning of *The Wind* (61), and Kvothe, witnessing its obedience, craves to have the knowledge of names like Sparrowhawk does: "Though I didn't know it at the time, I was looking for the name of the wind."(Rothfuss 64)

1.4.3 The language of true names – Old Speech – and its arbitrariness

Comoletti and Drout (2001) compare the nature of the Old Speech, in which true names are spoken, with the Saussure's concept of *signifier* and *signified* (Saussure 65-70). They demonstrate that the Old Speech is the same language Segoy used to create the world—that it is the "creation language,"(119) referring to Le Guin's words:

Once, at the beginning of time, when Segoy raised the isles of Earthsea from the ocean deeps, all things bore their own true names. And all doing of magic...hangs still upon the knowledge...of that true and ancient language of the *Making*.(The Tombs of Atuan 107)

The "language of Making" or the Old Speech was once spoken throughout the Earthsea. As the language evolved it lost the original meaning and power and the only speakers who still remember the original are wizards and the dragons (native speakers of the tongue), Comoletti and Drout explain.(119) Then they proceed with the thought of signifier/signified relationship being non-arbitrary in the Old Speech:

In the Old Speech the creator Segoy named all the objects in the world, creating them as he named them. Thus the relation between the signifier and the signified is *not* arbitrary; Saussure's rules do not apply.(119)

This union of a name and a thing that happened when Segoy created a particular thing by speaking its true name directly opposes Saussure's view of a linguistic sign - "the

whole that results from the associating of the signifier with the signified.”(67) A name or a term in the Old speech unites an actual thing and its name as we will see below, while Saussure’s linguistic sign “unites... but a concept and a sound-image.”(Saussure 66)

Comoletti and Drout point out a situation when signifier and signified “collapse into the *same thing*.”(119-120) In the scene, where Sparrowhawk’s teacher speaks the true name of a rock, a pebble appears in his hand: “The old Master murmured one word, “*Tolk*,” and there lay the pebble.”(*Wizard* 43) The word *Tolk* signifies a rock, but at the same time it is the rock, *Tolk* is the true name of the rock. Comoletti and Drout conclude that the Old Speech has the ability “to describe the world perfectly and to change it.”(120)

Contrary to the nature of true names of the Old Speech, the non-arbitrariness of “Names” in *The Wind* cannot be judged by a creation story alone. There is a short reference to the creation of world which includes *naming* of things, but no mention of a special language is given:

‘In the beginning, as far as I know, the world was spun out of the nameless void by Aleph, who gave everything a name. Or, depending on the version of the tale, found the names all the things already possessed.’(Rothfuss, 52)

Therefore, there is no telling, how motivated this Aleph’s choice of names was. However, at the end of the novel, the nature of true names is explained in more detail and the text suggests that the true names are motivated. We will look at the matter more closely in the analysis. For now the conclusion stands that there are visible similarities between *Earthsea* cycle and *The Wind*: in both worlds there existed an entity that in the beginning named all things.

1.5 Characteristics of names in *Harry Potter* series

While Le Guin’s *Earthsea* cycle we discussed above is a world “with its own history, ecology and culture”(Butler 234), the world of *Harry Potter* that we will focus on now “is always recognisable as a version of the mundane – ironized, inverted, exaggerated, or otherwise transformed.”(Butler 234) Both works are considered representatives of

contemporary children's fantasy, alongside with works of Pullman or Garner, and Butler recognises their diversity(234). Let us then turn our attention to Rowling's unique approach to names and naming in Potter series, in which she manifested a great skill and playfulness. First we will look at how magic leaves traces in names of ordinary things, then at the language devices, namely tropes that Rowling used to create names for her characters.

1.5.1 Magic leaving traces in names of things

In her article "Harry Potter and the Extraordinariness of the Ordinary," Natov reflects on Rowling's ability to animate everyday things. What connects these "ordinary" things and makes them special is magic and indeed, there are generally titled as "magical" in the story and bear tell-tale names, such as "Bertie Bott's Every Flavour Beans" for candy (where "every flavour" is not meant as a hyperbole), or "*Fantastic Beasts and Where to Find Them* by Newt Scamader" for a book.(Natov 315 and 319) By giving eye-catching titles to things, Rowling leaves a message for the reader that the object she just mentioned was made/written by a magician, probably contains some sort of magic, and has special abilities. The same thing e.g. a car or a pencil without magic would be just an ordinary thing like those from non-magical world of "muggles".

"Rowling ingeniously enhances and amplifies the vitality of ordinary objects,"(315) says Natov and names examples of special abilities typical for magical things: portraits in Rowling's novels talk, books can bite, candy surprises the consumer with a vile taste etc.(315) as if all were alive. Butler also comments on animation in Rowling's work and sees it as one of the "familiar literary models"⁶ that helps Rowling to "produce her brand of the fantastic." (233) She also points out that while in HP animation is "generally comic" (e.g. bickering portraits), it might be used as "effective horror technique" e.g. as in *Coraline* (2002) by Neil Gaiman.(234)

Analogically, inanimate objects e.g. wind, or fire in *The Name of the Wind* can be reanimated if a person speaks their true name (the wind will cradle a person, halting their fall, the fire will dim or flare, as told). One of Rothfuss' characters explains: "Most

6 Other models Butler named are: realization, substitution, exaggeration and antiquation.(234)

things are alive in one way or another.”(615) This looks like magic, although most characters in the novel would refrain from using the term, calling it the “art of naming.” In the same way, the author refrains from overusing commanding things by their true names through his characters (there are only about seven instances). Contrary to Rowling’s style, Rothfuss prefers to keep ordinary objects alive in the reader’s eyes, referring to their “potential” only. In the world where all things have a true name, this fact alone ensures that the reader is aware of the “magical” under the surface; however, it is mostly Kvothe and his goal to find the true name of the wind that will not allow us to forget magic: “I *was* determined to learn the name of the wind.”(304)

1.5.2 Tropes in *Harry Potter* Series

Another feature of Rowling’s style is the use of tropes and schemes that hide information in proper names of her characters. Trope is a “figure of speech, especially one that uses words in senses beyond their literal meaning...tropes change the meanings of words, by a ‘turn’ of sense.”(Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 342) Schemes, on the other hand, “merely rearrange their normal order.”(Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 342) As the majority of proper names occurring in *The Name of the Wind* are first names (surnames are introduced rarely, mainly for emphasis) and rearranging of the order of names is rare, we will focus mainly on tropes and how they are featured in Rowling’s work.

Let us look at the chosen tropes Rowling used in *Harry Potter* (further referenced only as H.P.) names. The following examples from H.P. are taken from the article “Naming Tropes and Schemes in J.K. Rowling’s *Harry Potter* Books” by Nilsen and Nilsen. The tropes are listed alphabetically. After them are introduced some schemes.

Allusion – “An indirect or passing reference to some event, person, place, or artistic work... not explained by the writer...relies on the reader’s familiarity with what is thus mentioned.(Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 9) Nilsens bring to our attention the phoenix “Fawkes,” which appears in the second sequel of the series; the species originates in Egyptian mythology, and the phoenix in H.P. even carries a name that reminds us of a real historical figure Guy Fawkes. Other mythological figures and legends are reflected in names of characters e.g. *Minerva*, *Narcissa*, *Hermes*.(61) As *The Name of the Wind* is set in purely fictional world, allusions are references to fictive but “real in the story”

characters e.g. *Taborlin the Great*. A character named *Elodin* refers to himself as *Elodin the Great*, alluding to the former and his legendary abilities connected with true names.

Archaism – “the use of words or constructions that have passed out of the language before the time of writing...may help to summon a nostalgic flavour of the past.” (Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 23) Archaisms are common in H.P. A spell *Cruciatus* has a Latin root, the village *Hogsmeade* carries a name of a drink *mead* drunk in the past, to name just a few.(62) Archaisms are less perceptible in *Wind*, but there are some made-up words with roots from classical languages e.g. *Hepten* (396) – a name of a day, or certain proper names e.g. *Heldred* (74) where the context explicitly says they are thousands years old, therefore in Rothfuss’ world can be considered archaic.

Circumlocutions – Nilsens shortly define them as “‘talking around’ the topic”(62); there are circumlocutions such as *Madame Maxime Olymp*, a half-giant, who is never referred to as fat, only “large-boned.”(ibid, 62)

Innuendo (i.e. subtle meanings) – Rowling uses less conspicuous innuendos as well, e.g. *Lily* and *Petunia*, names for Harry’s mother and her sister. Nilsens explain symbolism of flowers in the H.P. novels: lilies are connected to purity, petunias to anger. Both these characters’ behaviour could be described by aligned characteristics of flowers.(62)

Litotes and meiosis are put into the same category, as the core of both is understatement. Litotes is “a figure of speech by which an affirmation is made indirectly by denying its opposite, usually with an effect of understatement:...[e.g.] not averse to a drink.”(Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 190) Meiosis is “the Greek term for understatement...something is referred to in terms less important than it really deserves...[e.g.] mortal wound [described as] ‘a scratch.’”(Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 201) Nilsens introduce examples such as *Fluffy* for a three-headed dog, or a charm *Riddikulus!* that is used to destroy dangerous apparitions with laughter.(63)

Oxymorons – many of the names in H.P. carry contrasting ideas and therefore are quite eye-catching; *Headless Hats*, *No-Heat Fireworks* etc.(Nilsen, 62)

Paralipsis – “or Latin *occupatio*... A rhetorical figure in which the speaker or writer draws attention to some important matter by pretending to pass over it...’not to

mention’.”(Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 246) In H.P. as well as in *The Name of the Wind* there are characters that other characters refuse to address by their proper names. Not wanting to say the names usually expresses their fear of the beings in question, Lord Voldemort in the former, or individual name bearers of Chandrian in the latter. Phrases such as *You-know-who* or *The Dark Lord* are used instead of the proper name in H.P. There also are some positive cases, Nilsens point out: Harry is referred to as *The boy who lived* as a sign of respect.(64)

Periphrases means “substituting a word or phrase for someone’s proper name.”(Nilsen, 64) *Nearly Headless Nick*, *The Gray Lady*, or *Moaning Myrtle* are just a few examples. An example from *The Wind* would be *Crazy Martin* (Rothfuss 16).

Synecdoche – “A common figure of speech (or trope) by which something is referred to indirectly, either by naming only some part or constituent of it (e.g. *Hands* for manual labourers) or—less often—by naming some more comprehensive entity of which it is a part (e.g. *The law* for a police officer).” (Baldick, *Oxford Dictionary* 329) Nilsens use *Voldemort’s* name as an example – they translate it as “running from death”(63); this character is known for his reluctance to die, so the meaning of his name represents his actions.

Nilsens name more tropes, however, those listed above can be found in *The Name of the Wind* and we will discuss them in the analytical part.

2 Introduction to *The Name of the Wind*

The following chapter briefly introduces *The Wind* as a work of fiction, characteristics of narrative, the topic of true names, and, lastly, the protagonist *Kvothe* as his bearing of more than a dozen names is quite exceptional. Introduced terminology is later to be applied in analytical part.

2.1 *Young adult Fiction*

An important change in fiction came with the rise of the novel at the beginning of the

eighteenth century and the shift from “general human types” to “particular people in particular circumstances”(Watt, 15). In contemporary fiction for young adults there is no Miller or Cook’s Tale who appeared in Geoffrey Chaucer’s *Canterbury Tales*. In *The Wind* there is Kvothe, his unique personality, his life, his troubles and he lives in a different world from ours. In more academic terms: his is “fantastic” or “secondary” world. Such worlds typically “have their own rules...invert or subvert the ordinary logic and law of nature...[and] are inhabited by extraordinary creatures.”(Pokrivčáková, 99) Some significant folk and fairy tale motifs, e.g. power of names, journey, orphan, magic helper etc.(Bobulová, 46) are visible in the story. As in the works of J.R.R. Tolkien, K. Le Guin and other works of high fiction (Pokrivčáková, 116), the hero struggles to fight evil in his world – from ordinary bullies to mythical beings called *Chandrian* who murdered his parents. Judging from the content, this book was written intentionally for young adults; although the protagonist tells the story of his childhood as an adult, in his narration he never neglects to describe his feelings of a child – helplessness, fear in some situations, simple joy and no worries in others.

2.2 Narrative

First let us look at how this story is “packaged” as Barry (2009) would describe it. Packaging is connected to narratives contained in a story. *The Wind* starts with “primary”, or “frame” narrative, and it is “the narrative which comes first.”(Barry 227) As usually, is not the main narrative (Barry 227); the main narrative is typically the “secondary” or “embedded” narrative which is contained in the primary one (Barry 227), and *The Wind* follows this principle. To be even more specific, frame narrative in *The Wind* is “double-ended”. It means the primary narrative starts the story and ends it as well (Barry 228); in this case it is a prologue called ‘A Silence of Three Parts’ and an epilogue with the identical name. What is more, primary narrative interrupts the secondary several times with “interludes,” which means frame narrative is also “intrusive”(Barry 228).

The biggest distinction that can be made between these narratives in *The Wind* has to do with point of view. While in the primary narrative Rothfuss makes use of “limited” or “selective” omniscience, meaning there is non-participating narrator who sometimes chooses to step to the mind of some characters (Kennedy 20), the secondary narrative is

told in the first person by the main protagonist *Kvothe*. This Kvothe is also present among the characters in the primary narrative and the narrator often refers to him as “the innkeeper” or simply “Kote;” we do not know much about him, only that he is a fugitive. Kvothe’s (secondary) narrative begins only at the end of chapter seven, when he finally resolves to tell the story of his life. It is recorded by Chronicler, a brave scribe who is risking his life collecting this story.

Later in the analysis, we will use some more literary terms to describe the context, therefore I shall introduce them now. The main focus lays on names, their implications and also their function in the text; in some cases there is need to distinguish between basic narrative modes: “diegesis” and “mimesis.”⁷ For Barry, diegesis is “telling or relating,” diegetic narrative is “rapid, panoramic, summarising.”(223) On the other hand, “showing or dramatising” are signs of mimetic narrative mode, it is “slow telling,” makes use of direct speech and creates “the illusion that we are seeing and hearing things for ourselves.”(Barry 223)

Another important technique is foregrounding. Foregrounding means “giving unusual prominence to one element or property of a text, relative to other less noticeable aspects.”(Baldick, *The Concise Oxford Dictionary*, 86)

2.3 Synopsis

I include a short synopsis of *The Wind* so that the analytical part can be better navigated.

The story begins with the primary narrative, at the time the protagonist Kvothe is around twenty four. After Chronicler comes to his inn, Kvothe decides to tell his life story (the secondary narrative). He starts from the time he is eleven, travelling with his parents as a part of travelling performers troupe. He meets Abenthy, his first teacher, an Arcanist from the University. After Kvothe witnesses how Abenthy calls the name of the wind, and the wind obeys his command, it is a real magic, he wants to learn the name, the true name of the wind.

Later, Kvothe's parents sing an unfortunate song. Because of the song, the beings that were supposedly a myth, the Chandrian, kill everyone in Kvothe's troupe, and he is the

⁷ The first to distinguish mimesis and diegesis was Plato, Book III of *The Republic* (Barry,233)

only survivor. After that he spends three years in the city of Tarbean as homeless. There he meets Trapis, who takes care of homeless children, and Skarpi, a storyteller who changes his life. After hearing the story about the Chandrian and Lanre, Kvothe resolves to go to the University Abenthy told him about.

Being exceptionally bright, he is admitted and quickly progresses through students' ranks, what causes no small amount of dislike. Moreover, he is ever struggling with poverty. The story then follows his follies and also heroic deeds, all the while he is searching for the true name of the wind, and at the end of the novel he speaks it for the first time.

Practical part: The analysis of *The Name of the Wind*

3 Functions and implications of names in *The Name of the Wind*

Before we start with analysing the text of *The Name of the Wind*, I shall introduce the structure in which the findings are organised. Due to the high number of categories into which names could be separated, e.g. surnames, geographical names, names of art and literature, species, technical etc., they are categorised according to their function instead. By function is meant their position in narrative, ranging from the least important, to the key names. I decided to organise them in this way to support the idea of centrality of names, which is the view of onomastics. The highest groups should therefore prove to be the most central.

- **Names of credibility:** narrator uses them to make his story more believable; as a rule, these names serve only as a background information, they rarely carry additional meaning, and their bearers are mentioned about once or twice, throughout the story. Into this category belong: names of geographical locations, fictitious literature, songs, buildings, minor characters. If these names were changed, it would not change the meaning of the story.
- **Names of social standing:** some names in this category might belong to minor characters, however they reveal the existence of a certain social hierarchy in the described society. Also, they are very important when the author uses stereotypes to illustrate a character (e.g. pompous noble, simple peasant). Here belong: honorifics, titles, and ranks, both that are known in the real world and those own for Rothfuss's world. Also, most of nationalities and ethnic groups names belong here. These must be consistent.
- **Names of quality:** also carry special meaning, but in sense of attributes. Usually, those are characters from the history of the fictional world – local legends, prophets, or present idols and popular people. The author uses them for description of other characters' personality, qualities, appearance, etc.

Occasionally, names of nations can appear in this category. As a rule are introduced in a context before being used as attributes.

- **“I am here” names:** proper names of secondary characters who appear in the story, but their names hide little if any special meaning connected to the plot; mostly they hide some meanings about the bearer. Names in this category are at risk of being categorised incorrectly, as the *King’s Killer Trilogy* is not yet finished at the time of writing and some proper names might acquire a new special meaning, or the meaning could be revealed in following sequels. It is also important to know that this category does not make distinctions among the importance of secondary characters, it merely focuses on the implications of their proper names. Therefore both closely related to the hero and minor characters are here.
- **Names of special meaning:** this group covers the names the meanings of which are there for the reader to infer in order to solve a plot mystery. Many meanings of these names are later explained by the author. In this category can be found anything from place names, to proper names, as long as they can be considered key-plot-unravelling. Also, names with capital “N” or true names belong here, as they are special for the fictional world in which they appear, and are the key plot constituents.
- **“I am legendary” names:** here belong the names of the selected few, who made it into protagonist versus antagonist category. As a rule, these are proper names of people. All are crucial for the plot development and carry multi-layered meanings and connotations. These names are, after careful analysis, reveal key parts of the plot or important character features of their bearer.

3.1 Names of credibility

Due to the length of the novel and narrator’s constant focus on names, the credibility category is perhaps the biggest in number, but the least elaborate. The names here carry little hidden meaning, nevertheless, their role in narrative is irreplaceable – they play the role of little details that make the reality described by the narrator more believable.

3.1.1 Exchangeable under conditions

Let us consider this simple example, where Trapis, a poor man from Tarbean, the city where Kvothe spent three years of his life, takes care of homeless children:

Trapis nodded and gestured to the next child. ‘Jen, you help Nathan bring his brother back.’ They hurried out. ‘Tam, since Nathan’s gone, you carry the water instead.’

‘Kvothe, you run for soap.’ He held out a halfpenny. ‘Go to Marna’s in the Wash. You’ll get better from her if you tell her who it’s for.’(Rothfuss, 211)

The scene is Kvothe’s farewell to Trapis before he leaves for the University in Imre. It is emotionally hard for the hero who has been an orphan for three years now and Trapis was the only one to take care of him. None of the names except these two are important – not to hero, the story, or the reader. If they were changed, the meaning of the text would stay the same. However, if they were omitted altogether, the sharpness of this memory that Kvothe relates would be lost. Moreover, the author would need to describe Trapis’s busyness by other means. The text as it is refers to an exact place in a city (the Wash), notes the presence of other children (Jen, Nathan, Tam etc.), and further describes connections Trapis has (a certain Marna in the city part called ‘the Wash’ is aware of his situation and helps). This act of including seemingly unimportant names and direct speech which involves them, demonstrates the difference between showing (mimesis), where we feel we witness the scene, and telling (diegesis). Therefore, omission of these names would change the narrative mode, and consequently, the impact of the text and its reception.

It is important to note that, even though exchanging the names from the example would not change the meaning of the scene, it could change its natural feel. The names such as Tam or Jen are common in Tarbean. Were they replaced by unusual names such as *Saxána* or *Martinko Klingáčik*, they would attract the reader’s attention (and there is no need for that, as this is the last and only time Kvothe and the reader hear of them). Not only they are not of Anglo-Saxon origin, they are also too long, and not compliant with the rest of the names in the novel. These examples are extreme, but aptly express the situation in question – that “names of credibility” have to be picked and applied in accordance with the rest of the literary piece and must not attract unnecessary attention

if they are not to be used later in the text.

3.1.2 Be accurate, we need facts

Names of credibility not only help to create authentic feel in situations as we have seen above; they also feel natural in the text, because people, and therefore the characters too, often refer to time, places, other people. Let us demonstrate on the following situation: Men in an inn sit around a table, drinking, and omniscient narrator comments on it as follows: “Everyone knew that something bad had happened out on his [Shep’s] farm last Cendling night.”(Rothfuss 5) In terms of selective omniscience, the narrator should know what exactly happened, but as a good storyteller will leave that for later (note the example is from the very beginning of the novel). However, if he were to leave out even the day when the incident happened, the narration could feel too vague. Indeed, why mention missing sheep and not comment on it further, when it is something that bothers the portrayed characters?

Even a false story that Kvothe makes up and bids his friend to tell has to be full of non-important facts to sound credible. One of the customers recognises Kvothe, so he fakes an injured leg to have an excuse to leave:

‘I was a city-licenced escort from Ralien. Wounded while successfully defending a caravan. Arrow in right knee. Three years ago. Summer. A grateful Cealdish merchant gave me money to start an inn. His name is Deolan. We were travelling from Purvis. Mention it casually.’(Rothfuss 29-30)

In this category appear names of places, of days and months etc. that Rothfuss made up, e.g. “Felling”, “Baedn-Bryt”, “Newarre.” The names can be absolutely inconspicuous, as those used in the previous excerpt, or they can call for attention on purpose, being made of tropes or schemes. Often, the names of books, songs, plays and generally anything connected to art in *The Wind*, are alliterated, ambiguous, witty, humorous and also contribute to creation of story background. Let us look at some of Rothfuss’ examples:

Songs: 'The Lay of Sir Savien Traliard', 'The Pontifex Always Ranks Under a Queen' (archaic “lay”, “pontiff”), 'The Ballad of Ben, Brewer Supreme' (alliterated)

Plays: *Felward's Falling*, *Farien the Fair* (alliterated)

Game: Seek the Stone (alliterated)

Subject taught at the University: Unlikely Maths (oxymoron)

Even about eighteen per cent of chapter titles are alliterated, and there are many more examples of tropes, all of them creating a substantial, completely believable fictional world. In contrast to Rowling's work, tropes in *The Wind* are mostly used only in this category, in less significant names. In the whole novel they are added carefully, like spices, staying more in background.

3.2 Names of social standing

Network of names in this category helps to support the social structure of fictional world. "Social standing" of a character combines both his or her social class and general position in the fictional world, that is their nationality, ethnicity, and race – if they are non-human beings. Otherwise racial matters are not overly pronounced; the author pays more attention to distinguishing nationalities and to prejudice concerning ethnic groups, namely *Edema Ruh*. As this term is important in connection to the protagonist, I shall elaborate on it further.

3.2.1 Ethnicity

The name Edema Ruh is used to refer to groups of travelling performers that have been "in the business" for generations; Kvothe identifies himself as a member of this group: "I am of the Edema Ruh. We were telling stories before Caluptena burned. Before there were books to write in." (Rothfuss, 51) Ruh do not have any common language, but share a certain way of life style, which is more important than being born as Ruh. Kvothe starts his narrative talking about Ruh and his parents: "They were Ruh down to their bones...[s]ave perhaps that my mother was a noble before she was a trouper." (Rothfuss, 54) He encounters many difficulties because of his origins, as many people at the University judge him because of it⁸: "I had very real obstacles to overcome close at hand. My poverty. My low birth." (304) However, being Ruh is also a source of

⁸ "Ruh" is often used as derogatory term. Negative connotations can be found in collocative attributes: "filthy, thieving Ruh" (Rothfuss, 493) or in names of venereal diseases: "*Edamete tass*" or "*nemserria*" transl. as "the Edema Drip" (ibid, 399)

pride for him, Kvothe's troupe was famous: "We were court performers, Lord Greyfallow's men."(ibid., 54) Baron Greyfallow's patronage contributes to the reputation of Kvothe's troupe, offers opportunities, protects: "Baron Greyfallow, and his name opened many doors that would ordinarily be closed to the Edema Ruh"

3.2.2 Titles and honorifics

The name of Baron Greyfallow was introduced as the first from many instances in the book where a noble name carries power and influence. Rothfuss uses many standard titles for nobility in names of characters: *The Penitent King*, *Lady Lackless*, *Count Threpe*, *Duchess Samista*, *Baron Jakis* etc. Most of these names fall into category of "credibility" above. Some, however, for example son of Baron Jakis – Ambrose Jakis – or Threpe are key to plot development. While the former hates Kvothe to a degree he uses his connections in an attempt to annihilate him, the latter tries to support Kvothe with his influence among other wealthy people. The strongest implications of bearing a title (or having an appearance of a noble) in the novel, except having powerful connections, is the stereotype concerning young nobility Rothfuss creates and makes use of on several occasions:

"Nobles' sons are one of nature's great destructive forces, like floods or tornadoes. When you're struck with one of these catastrophes, the only thing an average man can do is grit his teeth and try to minimise the damage."(Rothfuss, 201)

This is the reason why Kvothe "gets away" with shouting at and offending people while pretending to be a noble in Tarbean in a clothes shop (Rothfuss 201-3) and later in Imre, buying a horse (Rothfuss 492-6). This example shows how even the appearance of having a noble name causes other people to obey:

"Fetch me a robe, lack-wit. I'm sick of being gawked by you and every other mewler that decided to go marketing today...DO YOU HAVE ANY IDEA WHO I AM?"

Bentley scurried away...I kept him running for half an hour...mocked the material, the cut, and workmanship...I was the perfect little brat.

In truth I couldn't have been more pleased.(Rothfuss, 201)

Many (but not all) young nobles follow this behavioural pattern, and readers even

expect them to, because Rothfuss introduced this stereotype in an unforgettable manner above. Encountering a noble name in the text therefore implies that the bearer will follow the pattern. On the other hand, not having a title or noble origin means that commoners will follow Bentley's example, "grit their teeth" and survive. That leaves plenty of place for the protagonist to be different and defy unreasonable behaviour of another University student Ambrose Jakis: "[M]y ongoing feud with Ambrose added to my reputation more than anything else. Everyone was stunned that I dared openly defy a powerful noble's firstborn son...I was a fool."(Rothfuss, 317-8)

The quarrels of the two are soon brought to the attention of Masters, the teacher at the University. The University has its own way of ranking the social position of the teachers and students. The highest position is that of a Master. There are nine of them⁹ and they function as an (entrance) exam and disciplinary committee, set the tuition fees, punish those who break University rules, and, most importantly, teach students. The position of a Master is the highest at the University and as a ruling organ they have the biggest influence, authority, and privileges. Under them follow positions of a "giller" that means any Arcanist¹⁰ that, after finishing studies, stays at the University to help masters teach, then positions that can be reached during studies (ranked from the highest to the lowest): "El'the"¹¹, "Re'lar" meaning speaker, "E'lir" meaning "see-er."(Rothfuss, 614) These names date back to the foundation of University and speak of a rank among members of Arcanum. Students are addressed accordingly; the reached rank speaks of their abilities and achievements in the disciplines.¹² Newly admitted students have no ranking until they prove their knowledge.

To sum up, titles and rankings that accompany character's name can indicate their possible behaviour towards characters of the same or different rank. Nobles in *The Wind* might act high-handed, if they do not, they break the expected pattern and are more memorable. Students might show friendliness or hostility to students with other ranks, e.g. most were hostile to Kvothe when he reached the rank of E'lir too early in his

⁹ Master Linguist (the Chancellor), Physicker, Archivist, Arithmetician, Artificer, Alchemist, Rhetorician, Sympatist, and Mater Namer(Rothfuss, 263)

¹⁰ Arcanist is a accomplished member of the Arcanum, the inner, originally secret, group at the University

¹¹ Term El'the is not explained in *The Wind*

¹² Disciplines taught at the University: medicine, languages, mathematics, artificing (or sygaldry), alchemy, rhetoric, sympathy, naming, history.

studies (higher rank means more privileges, such as an access to information). The situation is described in more detail in 3.6.2.

3.3 Names of quality

This category partially overlaps with the “social standing” category, as some of the above mentioned examples are used as attributes: “a lowly E’lir”, “thieving Ruh”(Rothfuss, 241 and 493). Names of quality are frequently used as similes “like Prince Gallant”(386, 450, 462), carry a reference, or simply describe a person/place/thing with the help of connotations they evoke. Connotations may be both positive and negative and the examples introduced below are strictly text-dependent, i.e. they assume certain descriptive value only in the fantastic world they are a part of. Examples such as Prince Gallant that can be understood without context are rare.

3.3.1 Names from legends

In the theoretical part, we already mentioned *Taborlin the Great*, a hero and a namer, famous enough to be alluded to by other characters, and to be mentioned at the very beginning of the novel in a legend. Despite the fact that it is not clear whether Taborlin really existed in this fantasy world, the protagonist idolizes him as a child, wants to learn “storybook magic,” to know how to call the wind, as Taborlin does in stories. He mentions Taborlin more than ten times throughout the story, and as a rule, Taborlin’s name is a positive attribute: “‘It means many things,’ I said in my best Taborlin the Great voice.”(Rothfuss, 393) Taborlin is mighty: “‘Who sent you?’ I demanded in my best Taborlin the Great voice.”(ibid, 477) He is a hero, too, and being compared to him is a compliment:

“Well, I heard one student say that you strode out of your office and called the fire’s name, just like Taborlin the Great. You said, ‘fire be still’ and the fire obeyed.”

Kilvin gave a great laugh. “I like that story.”(Rothfuss, 457)

Taborlin’s is a singular name. Another hero is *Oren Velciter*, mentioned on four occasions (this character is real and alive, the Chronicler recorded his story(48)). His

name is even used in comparisons, however, it is far from having the same impact on the story as Taborlin's. Referring to Velciter only strengthens the authenticity of the world. For example, two people are talking about a horse; one says: "“But if he's all black then I'm Oren Velciter,””(500) and by this basically accuses the other one of lying, as it is obviously impossible he would be that well-known hero.

There is yet one important name, a name of a group of uncertain origin, the Order of Amyr. Perhaps it is not used to make comparisons, but carries strong positive connotations for Kvothe. Let us consider following examples by Rothfuss: Most of people regard Amyr as a part of long gone history: "The Amyr were a part of the church back when the Aturan Empire was still strong."(254-5) But they are considered heroic enough that at least children take their name as a positive attribute: "When we are young we all pretend to be Amyr and fight battles with willow-switch swords."(255) Kvothe, however, has strong reasons to believe they still exist. After his parents are murdered, he witnesses the Chandrian seriously talking about Amyr as a threat: "“*Who keeps you safe from the Amyr? The singers? The Sithe?*””(117) As Kvothe remembers this line years later after hearing Skarpi's story¹³, he realizes the Amyr are his only solution to fight Chandrian:

I knew revenge was nothing more than a childish fantasy...[but] Chandrian had enemies. If I could find them, they would help me.

...I had questions. There was only one place for me to go.(Rothfuss, 193-4)

This is the moment when, after almost three years of living homeless in Tarbean, Kvothe decides to go to the University, to look for the information on Amyr in the famous University Archives. The name of Amyr carries enough power, enough positive connotations for Kvothe to believe this possible. Basically, it is because of their name and the power it carries that Kvothe decides to change his life. Therefore, names of quality are not only used as attributes, but also as elements that change the flow of the story.

3.3.2 Places

The reader discovers connotations these place-names evoke as the story unfolds. First

¹³ Skarpi is a storyteller. We will discuss his role in 3.5.

they are usually only mentioned in a conversation. A girl Denna talks about where she is headed: “‘Right now I’m thinking Anilin.’”(Rothfuss, 215) Several pages later we find out more than just a fact that Anilin is a city: “‘You could come to Anilin with us... [t]hey say the streets are paved with gold there.’”(ibid, 224) As the protagonist never goes there in the first sequel of the trilogy, we have no way to know whether it is true. However, it is certain that not everything is so ideal in Anilin and speaking its name brings unpleasant memories; one night, Kvothe is attacked in an alley by two men. He is certain they were sent by the noble Ambrose to kill him and that they are waiting only to make sure they have the right person. One of the attackers says: “Check it now...I’m not having another cock-up like in Anilin.”(ibid, 475) There are criminals in Anilin and not all people like it there. Kvothe asks Denna what happened there after her return from Anilin: “Nothing pleasant.”(ibid, 443)

Kvothe bears his own unpleasant memories of Tarbean. There, he was robbed, beaten, molested. We need to look at the context to understand the implications of “Tarbean” attributes. This is the way he describes this vast city:

It is like the ocean...You could live your whole life in Tarbean and never know all its parts.

But for most practical purposes Tarbean had two pieces: Waterside and Hillside. Waterside is where people are poor. That makes them beggars, thieves, and whores. Hillside is where people are rich. That makes them solicitors, politicians, and courtesans.(Rothfuss, 143-4)

Hillside was rich. Waterside stank.(ibid, 206)

This description and other events from his life in Tarbean that Kvothe talks about allow the reader to understand following excerpts. They show how “Waterside” connotations are able to describe people or situation: “Waterside money was tight and an empty begging bowl meant a cold, hungry night,”(Rothfuss, 166) and create contrast: “This wasn’t some Waterside guard. He was clean-shaven and upright...carried a brass bound club.”(ibid, 147) Being familiar with the context of the book helps the reader to interpret attributes consisting of names made up by the author that, outside of their “home” fictional world do not have a meaning.

3.4 “I am here” names

Over six hundred pages long novel such as *The Wind* mentions dozens of characters; therefore rather than name them all, we shall look at the patterns that appear in the book. As a rule, in the secondary narrative, Kvothe names all people, even those he will not mention again. The only exception are the people there is no reason for him to know the names of (or he does not hear them spoken by other people) and that includes most of the inn owners, shop assistants and other staff members, regardless of whether Kvothe talks to them, describes their appearance or not. Following text describes the patterns of foregrounding, names reflecting profession, women names, surnames and couples, and motivated names.

3.4.1 Foregrounding and names

There are names that could be considered foregrounded, e.g. Puppet (274, 356). After asking who Puppet is, Kvothe gets this reply: “‘Hard to describe...I’ll introduce you later.’”(274) However Kvothe never gets to meet Puppet in the first book, so Puppet’s name might be a red herring as well. Although the truth is Puppet’s name is also one of a kind and stands out, therefore it is safe to expect he will be important in some of the following sequels. Indeed, he appears in the second sequel of the trilogy, *The Wise Man’s Fear* (2011), and helps Kvothe with his research, as he is an expert librarian.

Other foregrounded names of indisputably important characters (they appear in the first part of the trilogy) are for example *Abenthy*, Kvothe’s first teacher: “He taught me more than all the others set end to end...I ask that you not hold it against him. He meant well.”(55), *Skarpi*, the storyteller: “‘I needed something, or someone, to wake me up...It was years before...I met Skarpi.’”(169) It is not the names themselves that tell the reader they are significant, but the way they are introduced. And as the last, Kvothe’s love interest *Denna*; he foregrounds her in the following way: “‘She is in the wings now, waiting for her cue. Let us set the stage for her arrival.’”(321)

In the novel, there are seven interludes (intrusive primary narrative) in total. In every single one is used the technique of foregrounding. Three of them foreground characters: Elodin, Skarpi, Denna, other foreground upcoming events. All of those characters were

mentioned even before their foregrounding took place, however Kvothe's narration (in Skarpi's case the narration of limited omniscient narrator) did not imply they will be crucial for the story. Therefore I stress here the later mention of these characters, the easily recognisable foregrounding. Names foregrounded in this way imply that their bearers are going to appear in the story and will have a key role in the plot development.

3.4.2 Names that reflect profession

One of the first profession-reflecting names we encounter is the nickname of a scribe Devan Lochees aka *Chronicler*. This name is quite direct, as he writes down people's last wills, their life-stories, etc. And there is less obvious name *Skarpi*. If it is derived from Italian *la scarpa* (i.e. a shoe), and I have strong suspicions it is, it would metaphorically refer to his livelihood. Kvothe describes Skarpi as "thin and weathered...deep brown tan[ned]"(173), an appearance common for people who travel and are often exposed to weather. Chronicler supports this idea of Skarpi, when he tells Kvothe: "'I've been travelling with a friend of yours. Skarpi.'"(43) And before Kvothe met Skarpi as a child, he heard a girl talking about the storyteller knowing "Any story you asked for."(170) Yet another reason to suspect he is a great traveller and collector of stories.

Basically, names that reflect profession of a bearer are like living walking banners, divulging the background of the given character, level of education (as in Chronicler's case), sometimes even life style (as in Skarpi's case).

3.4.3 Women names

Despite the explanation that the "ratio of men to women in the University is about ten to one,"(Rothfuss, 250) one might get a feeling there are even fewer women than that. Both female students Kvothe makes an acquaintance of bear names ending in *-la*: Mola, Fela. Considering other women names from the novel: Rian, Reta, Denna, Devi, etc. a *-la* ending cannot be called a special trend (it is not repeated in more female names). Neither Kvothe's memory is at fault to mention these similar names for the representatives of feminine minority, as it is "so clean and sharp [he has] to be careful not to cut [himself] sometimes."(Rothfuss, 169) Therefore, we can conclude that Mola

and Fela, despite not being at liberty to bear original names, have at least names that make them distinguishable from the rest of the University populace.

There is even more outstanding female character Denna, who is one of few characters that bear more than one name. She, being Kvothe's love interest (and he, being perpetually out of luck), must necessarily randomly appear and then disappear out of his life (and the story). Whenever he meets her again, people around her know her by a different name, always starting with D-: Denna, Dianne, Dyanae, Dinnaeh. An acquaintance of Kvothe's offers him some insight into her "circumstances":

Young gents court her, buy her presents...If she sells those things for money to live, there's nothing wrong in that...But what is she to do when some gent gets too familiar?...No family, no friends, no standing. No choice. None but to give herself over to him, all unwilling...Or to leave. Leave quickly and find better weather. (Rothfuss, 473)

She is the girl who travelled to Anilin, then fled to Imre, a city close to the University. She said to Kvothe once: "I leave where I'm not welcome...Everything else I can make up along the way." (Rothfuss, 507) Her changing name captures her "wild" nature and it is also a signal to the reader; as Kvothe said: "Her wildness is of such degree, I fear approaching her too quickly even in a story." (ibid, 322) New names mean new beginnings – Vula'a rename places, after something important happens there, to remember the history (Van Heekeren, 170); Le Guin has her characters take new names on important occasions, such as a naming ceremony, where they are given a true name, which carries a message about them. (Robinson, 393-4) Denna, on the other hand, possibly adopts new names to stay unrecognised, and to forget. She always runs away from a place that evokes unpleasant memories.

3.4.4 Surnames and couples

Although surnames exist in the novel, they are used rarely, and not all characters seem to have one. When used, it is mainly for emphasis, or as a warning: "Are you telling this story, Jacob Walker?' Cob said sharply." (Rothfuss, 5) or "Alder Whin is not to be confined...I am holding you responsible for this, Timothy Generoy." (309)

Another interesting feature of “I am here” names is how Rothfuss alliterates the names of some couples e.g. Lanre and Lyra (80) from an old legends, or Roent and Reta (208), the wagoneers Kvothe travels with on his way to the University.

3.4.5 Motivated names

Secondary characters, unlike the background characters mentioned in 3.1., are accompanied by sufficient information on their personality and (or) appearance that it is possible to speculate about motivation of their names. I say speculate not because I am not prepared to support my claims with evidence, but simply because I am aware that even the best justification might be proven incorrect by the author, who is the only one to know the true reasons for choosing a particular name. Nevertheless, I shall proceed as I believe that without considering motivated names, this analysis would not be complete.

Firstly, let us prove that Rothfuss uses motivated names, and does so intentionally. In one of the stories the storyteller Skarpi tells, characters¹⁴ are introduced in the following way:

Fair Geisa, who had a hundred suitors in Belen before the walls fell. The first woman to know the unasked-for touch of man...And beside her came Andan, whose face was a mask with burning eyes, whose name meant anger.(Rothfuss, 188)

If Andan’s name means “anger” in this fictional world, and if his appearance, e.g. “burning eyes” can be understood as a sign of anger too, then his name is motivated. Name Geisa could be an allusion to word “geisha,” defined in *OALD* as “woman who is trained to entertain men with conversation, dancing and singing.” Geisa is popular and being in her company is probably entertaining; moreover, the expression “unasked-for” suggests she was forced to do more than is expected from her. Therefore I see Geisa as a motivated name.

As the list of all motivated names would be too long, I shall introduce selected examples; if any of the introduced names are explained in *The Wind*, it will be stated so.

¹⁴ Although the chosen examples are from the background names category, and the accompanying descriptions are short, they are able to prove motivation.

Elodin – one of the Masters at the University, a Namer. His name is similar to “melody” and the way he speaks, sometimes behaves reminds of music: “Elodin’s light voice moved through deep places in your chest when he spoke”(Rothfuss 268). His behaviour is unpredictable, it changes like tones in music; he is “one moment watching something intently, the next minute bored and letting his attention wander...He was almost like a child who had been forced to sit down with adults”(Rothfuss 233).

Eolian – a high-class inn, where artists (mainly musicians and singers) perform in order to win “talent pipes,” a silver badge equivalent to a certificate, acknowledging their distinct talent. According to *OALD*, eolian means “connected with or caused by the action of the wind;” this explanation in connection with the talent pipes seems logical enough. However, even more appropriate would be the connection to Æolian, “a wind-played instrument.”(Gilman, 143)

Perial – reminds of “pearl.” In Trapis’ story, pages 155-165, (tho story could be considered an equivalent to a biblical story), she is the last pure soul in the world, gives a birth to God, Menda, to save the world. Pearls are rare, pure, white, as is Perial’s behaviour and her soul.

Skarpi – see 3.4.2.

Motivated names are not rare in the novel, however determining their motivation might seem subjective. Therefore I do not claim the above to be absolutely accurate connections of character’ names and the motivations behind those names.

3.5 *Names of special meanings*

Many of the names in this category are motivated; however, they differ from motivated names in the previous subchapter – they carry a message that can help the reader to solve a plot mystery before the author reveals it, or, from the opposite point of view, they help the author to hide information, to maintain tension, until the right time to explain arrives (which often means the time the hero solves the mystery). True names differ in many more directions, so let us shed some light on the topic.

3.5.1 True names

“Names are the shape of the world, and a man who can speak them is on the road to power,”(Rothfuss 614) Master Namer Elodin tells Kvothe. Then he adds that in the past “Arcanum was a strong brandy. Now it is well-watered wine.”(ibid.) Indeed, among current members of the Arcanum i.e. students, Masters, and graduates (Arcanists) that reached a certain degree of knowledge, are not many¹⁵ who know true names. To know more than one is rare, and even then, a person might not be able to use the name to its full potential. Master Kilvin talks to Kvothe about the name of fire: “There may be one or two others here at the University, but Elodin has the surest grip of it.”(458) This implies that true names in Rothfuss’ world are volatile. While there is no occasion in the story when intentional calling of a true name would go awry, the message about watered wine gets communicated, as there are only seven occasions in the story when somebody calls a name, plus two more, if we take into account the legends (stories) told by other characters¹⁶.

Despite the fact that true names (in Rothfuss’ terminology Names) are called rarely, the procedure is always the same. Firstly, a person speaks the Name of a thing aloud, “as if it was an order to be obeyed”(Rothfuss 92); any other people present, if they do not know the Name of the thing, hear just an ordinary name instead, e.g. “iron” or “wind.” This is quite different from the concept of true names in Earthsea, where people are careful, lest somebody else overhears. Sparrowhawk’s aunt tells him, before teaching him the name of a falcon: “You will not ever tell that word to the other children, if I teach it to you...We must keep secrets of our craft.”(Le guin, *A Wizard* 4) For comparison, the following excerpt is from the scene where Master Elodin helps Kvothe to call the wind to calm his mind. Kvothe already called the wind once, his friend Simmon did not, so he does not understand:

‘*Aerlevsedi*,’ he said. ‘Say it.’

‘What?’ Simmon said somewhere in the distant background. ‘Wind?’

...‘*Aerlevsedi*,’ I said numbly.(Rothfuss 606)

Secondly, after calling its Name properly, the thing obeys the caller (as in Earthsea).

¹⁵ The University has about 1500 students. See Rothfuss, 311.

¹⁶ Those are the story about Taborlin the Great, p. 3-4, and the legend about Lanre and Selitos, p. 174-181 and 186-9.

Kvothe describes how he saw Ben, his first teacher, call the wind in self-defense:

I saw his mouth move.

A furious gust of wind came out of nowhere...The constable staggered and fell as if he had been struck by the hand of God.(Rothfuss 61)

However, unintentional calling of a Name for the first time might leave unpleasant after-effects. As Kvothe put it: “Suddenly, violently dizzy I cried out and raised my hands to keep myself from falling sideways, falling upward, falling inward.”(Rothfuss 607) Kvothe's first calling of the wind was triggered by anger; it was the same for Elodin. He says: ““You are not the first student to call the name of the wind in anger, though you are the first in several years. Some strong emotion usually wakes the sleeping mind.””(Rothfuss 616)

Waking up a “sleeping mind” is a necessary condition to being able to call Names. The opposite of sleeping mind is a “waking mind.” Master Namer explains:

Our waking mind is what thinks and talks and reasons. But the sleeping mind is more powerful. It sees deeply to the heart of things. It is the part of us that dreams. It remembers everything. It gives us intuition. Your waking mind does not understand the nature of names. Your sleeping mind does. It already knows many things that your waking mind does not.(Rothfuss 615)

This implies that Names in Rothfuss’ world cannot be simply taught as in Earthsea. As Elodin says: ““The nature of names cannot be described, only experienced and understood.”” What he does not say is that the price of understanding includes enduring some dubious teaching methods, e.g. walking with mud in your shoes, being woken up in the middle of the night, or simply staring at fallen leaves dancing in the wind, trying to find patterns in their movement.

3.5.2 Dangers and misuse of true names

Looking for Names is difficult, sometimes strange and dangerous too. People at the University need to undergo various kinds of mind-exercises, e.g. dividing their mind into several independent parts, to be able to hold in it several different (often opposing) beliefs at once. Elodin asks Kvothe: ““Why does a University with under fifteen

hundred students need an asylum the size of the royal palace?...Because of the way we train our minds to move.”(Rothfuss 311) This asylum is also known as “Haven”, “the Rookery” or “the Crockery.” Elodin himself spent some time in there, and is an object of many jokes throughout the book.

How searching for Names and their careless use might be dangerous and lead to evil is expressed in the story Kvothe hears from Skarpi¹⁷, and also in still prevailing prejudice of common folk towards people at the University. Should one introduce themselves as an arcanist, he might encounter disapproval at least, hostility at most. Following piece is from the scene where Abenthy, an arcanist, comes to a town to sell his goods:

‘I’m an arcanist, you great dithering heap of idiot.’

‘My point exactly,’ the mayor said doggedly. ‘We’re God-fearing people in these parts. We don’t want any meddling with dark things better left alone. We don’t want the trouble your kind can bring.’(Rothfuss 60)

Common people are afraid of power of arcanists, especially those who know true names. That is why the members of Arcanum must follow strict University rules and never use their power to harm others. The act of harming somebody with magic is called “malfeasance”(Rothfuss 264) and one can be lashed and expelled from the University if he is found guilty. The rules are there to protect common people and arcanists as well: “A few hundred years ago arcanists were hunted down and burned for things of that sort. We do not tolerate [malfeasance].”(ibid. 264)

3.5.3 Arbitrariness of true names

In the theoretical part I stated that it is not possible to judge whether the true names in *The Wind* are arbitrary solely on the creation story contained in the book. Let us then inspect some textual evidence. When a reader encounters the word “cyaerbasalien”(Rothfuss 313), there is a possibility he or she will discard it as a nonsense word, ergo arbitrary. If the word was onomatopoeic (based on some sound), but clearly it is not, then there would be a chance to consider it a non-arbitrary signifier. (Saussure 69) We need to change our point of view to understand the nature of true names. In the following example Elodin explains to Kvothe the difference between an

¹⁷ The story by Skarpi is discussed in 3.6.1

arbitrary word and a true name:

‘What colour is that boy’s shirt?’

‘Blue.’

‘What do you mean by blue? Describe it.’

I struggled for a moment, failed. ‘So *blue* is a name?’

‘It is a word. Words are pale shadows of forgotten names. As names have power, words have power...But a word is nothing but a painting of a fire. A name is the fire itself.’

A name is the thing itself. It is the same in Earthsea; the word *Tolk* in the Old Speech is the signifier for a rock, but at the same time it is the rock itself. True names in *The Wind* are motivated. In one of the examples above, the wind appears “out of nowhere” when Abenthy calls its name. So does a rock appear in his hand, when a sorcerer speaks its name in *Wizard*.(Le Guin 43)

Although Names might not be easy to learn, and some are ever-changing like the name of the wind, one fact remains the same – the Names are powerful; this archetype of power of a name is perceptible in the works of Le Guin and also in *rikwana*, stories of Vula’a. In all three sources it is necessary to speak the true name aloud to make its bearer obey.

3.6 “I am legendary” names

As Pokrivčáková says, fantasy literature “bears a serious deal of morality in itself: the struggle between good and evil, questions of loyalty and devotion to friends”(100). *The Wind* is no exception, and provides fine specimens for analysis. Let me introduce Haliar, the antagonist, the personification of evil, the despised murderer of Kvothe’s parents, a fallen once-great warrior, and Kvothe, the protagonist, an exceptionally bright person, an innkeeper and also a red-handed killer, waiting for his death. None of them is black-and-white, and both hide more than is revealed in the first book of *The Kingkiller Chronicle* trilogy. They also do not fight each other in *The Wind*; however, I believe it to be appropriate to introduce Haliar as Kvothe’s opponent, mainly because of the way his identity, motivation, and names are revealed (and hidden too) in the text. Let us

proceed with Haliax as the first.

3.6.1 Haliax

If it were not for the prologue “A Silence of Three Parts,” the Chandrian, a common name for Haliax and his group of followers, would be introduced in the text sooner than the protagonist. They are mentioned in a tavern tale on page one of the first chapter alongside with the unmistakeable sign of their presence – all fire turning blue. Until they actually appear in the story, they are always referred to as a whole group “the Chandrian,” no proper names are mentioned. At most, different members of the group are alluded to in a children’s song by following phrases “his eyes are black as crow” and “a man without a face”(Rothfuss 27). These attributes will be later recognised as the description of Cinder and Haliax, respectively. Below is the whole chant. I include it because it later turns out to be very true, and also because Kvothe points out that the facts in songs are significant: “You’d be surprised at the sorts of things hidden away in children’s songs”(Rothfuss 37). The song about the Chandrian goes as follows:

*When the hearthfire turns to blue,
What to do? What to do?
Run outside. Run and hide.
When his eyes are black as crow?
Where to go? Where to go?
Near and far. Here they are.
See a man without a face?
Move like ghosts from place to place.
What's their plan? What's their plan?
Chandrian. Chandrian.(Rothfuss 26-7)*

The chant clearly states that the Chandrian are dangerous and that one should “run and hide,”(Rothfuss 26) and they are also unpredictable: “Near and far. Here they are”(Rothfuss 27), meaning they appear out of nowhere and then simply disappear.¹⁸ People are afraid of this unfamiliarity and uncertainty. Nevertheless, mentioned only in tales and songs, nobody expects them to really turn up in the story. Even more bizarre is the reason they do – Kvothe’s parents sing a song about them, and in the song, unlike

¹⁸ Kvothe witnesses their departure saying they were suddenly gone: “as if they were made of sand with wind blowing across them, they faded away”(Rothfuss 118).

children in the chant, they mention proper names. It is revealed later in the story that Haliar and Lanre are the same person. I include the song for comparison:

*Sit and listen all, for I will sing
A story, wrought and forgotten in a time
Old and gone. A story of a man.
Proud Lanre, strong as the spring
Steel of the sword he had at ready hand.
Hear how he fought, fell, and rose again,
To fall again. Under shadow falling then.
Love felled him, love for native land,
And love of his wife Lyra, at whose calling
Some say he rose, through doors of death
To speak her name as his first reborn breath.*(Rothfuss 108)

To compose this song, Kvothe's parents collected rhymes, songs and tales about Chandrian for years. The reactions of people were always the same: they are reluctant to say much on the topic. Kvothe's father calls them "superstitious country folk"(Rothfuss 81). Therefore he is very surprised when he asks Abenthy, Kvothe's first teacher and an arcanist, and his reaction is similar. "I'd appreciate it if you didn't say them out loud. Names of people, that is,"(Rothfuss 84) Abenthy says. He points out that while every region has its own superstitions and people there are afraid of things that are elsewhere dismissed as a myth, e.g. demons, the Fae (fairies), shamble-men, the Chandrian are feared everywhere: "But folk everywhere are afraid of them. There's usually a reason for that."(Rothfuss 86)

It was months before the Chandrian came to exact their revenge. Kvothe was only twelve and after he returned to their camp, he found all his troupe murdered and the Chandrian sitting around a fire. "Someone's parents...have been singing entirely the wrong sort of songs,"(Rothfuss 116) said Cinder, the only named Chandrian except for Haliar. That is how we know they came because of the song. When Kvothe notices Haliar, he describes him in the following way: "shadow pooled around him like thick oil...[it] gathered thicker around his head...the shadows were so deep it was like looking down a well at midnight,"(Rothfuss 116). He further refers to him as "the shadowed man," "the dark man," or by his "cool voice," when he speaks, and finally by his name

Haliar, when Cinders mentions it (Rothfuss 116-7). When Kvothe's father and Abenthy talked about the Chandrian, they mentioned one of them being "yoked to shadow" or "shadow-hamed" (Rothfuss 84), a description that perfectly fits Haliar. These features are stressed so many times it would not be surprising, if Haliar was a motivated name.

In *Oxford Dictionary of English Etymology*, there is an entry "hale," which means "draw, pull, first recorded in 8th cent. - Old and Modern French *haler* - Old Saxon *halōn* (= Old Frisian *halia*...possibly related to Latin *calāre*, Greek *kaleîn* call)" (424). Interesting is Old Frisian "halia," only one letter short of Haliar. When we compare the meaning of halia and Haliar's description, it seems as if he really drew or pulled shadows to him. Moreover, his name could be some sort of a "call," as he comes when it is mentioned. However, there is no way of proving this assumption to be correct.

There is no need to describe how deeply these events affected Kvothe. The next time he hears about the Chandrian is three years later in Tarbean, where he lives as a homeless orphan. The story is called "Lanre and the Creation War," (Rothfuss 174) and is told by Skarpi, the storyteller. It speaks of long gone past, unending wars, powerful namer *Selitos*, and a great warrior *Lanre*. Then, in one battle, Lanre died. His wife Lyra, a namer like Selitos, called his name to bring him from dead: "[she] spoke his name. Her voice was a commandment...Her voice was beckoning...a whisper...begged him to live again" (Rothfuss 176). And she succeeded: "But Lanre heard her calling...From beyond the doors of death Lanre returned" (Rothfuss 177). The last two lines of Kvothe's parents' song refer to this event: "*Some say he rose, through doors of death To speak her name as his first reborn breath.*" (Rothfuss 108) Years later, Lyra died. Lanre, knowing the power of names and that his wife was able to bring him back to life, decided to search for this knowledge. However, he was unable to bring her back and he changed. He tried to kill himself, but always unsuccessfully; his newly acquired power brought him to life again and again. Lanre thought the only one able to help him was Selitos:

'Destroy the world?' Selitos said softly to himself. 'You are not mad, Lanre. What grips you is something worse than madness. I cannot cure you.'

...'Can you kill me, old friend?'

'I can...But you would return...Your name burns with the power in you.'

‘I am no longer the Lanre you knew. Mine is a new and terrible name. I am Haliar and no door can bar my passing.’(Rothfuss 179-180)

Lanre lost all hope to find anything good in life and he destroyed the city that Selitos protected, determined to destroy everything and fall into oblivion. Selitos cursed him, using his own powers as a namer:

‘By the power of my own blood I bind you’...Selitos spoke the long name that lay in Lanre’s heart...‘Your own name will be turned against you, that you shall have no peace...This is my doom upon you and all who follow you. May it last until the world ends.’(Rothfuss 181)

These excerpts are introduced as a story, but Kvothe believes them to be true. The truth put aside, the message of the story is clear; it cautions against misusing powers of naming and waking the dead. Haliar’s name is a curse and implies that he will probably be here while people remember his name.

The Chandrian enter the story in the book once more. Again, the evidence that Kvothe uncovers indicates that the Chandrian kill everyone who knows or sees a certain proof of their existence. While Kvothe’s troupe suffered because of song that mentioned proper names, a whole family died in the town called Trebon, because they dug at a place named “Borrill,” originally called “Barrow Hill”(Rothfuss 532, 536). They found old barrows and took an ancient vase from there. Kvothe managed to find only one witness who saw the vase and lived, a girl Nina. After she described the pictures painted on the item, he concluded that they depicted the Chandrian and their signs. (Rothfuss 595)

Let us summarize facts about Haliar’s name and implications that can be derived from it. All associations arising from the term “the Chandrian,” and that extends to the particular members, Haliar included, are negative. Haliar, as a member of the Chandrian, evokes fear to a degree people will not say his name. If the name Haliar is connected to Old Frisian *halia*, then it is also motivated, as he “pulls” shadow towards him, is “shadow-named”(Rothfuss 84). Lastly, with the name Haliar is connected the former name of the bearer – Lanre – that also signifies past glory, a great sorrow and madness. This change of name and also a true name indicates that even a true name of a

person can change during their life, similarly like the name of the wind can change.

3.6.2 Kvothe

Kvothe is a singular protagonist as far as names (and their number) are concerned. And the best way to introduce him is to let him introduce himself. We will use the text later for reference:

My name is Kvothe, pronounced nearly the same as “Quothe”. Names are important as they tell you a great deal about a person. I’ve had more names than anyone has a right to.

The Adem call me Maedre. Which, depending on how it’s spoken, can mean “The Flame”, “The Thunder” or “The Broken Tree”.

“The Flame” is obvious if you’ve ever seen me. I have red hair, bright. If I had been born a couple hundred years ago I would probably have been burned as a demon.

...“The Thunder” I attribute to a strong baritone and a great deal of stage training at an early age.

I’ve never thought of “The Broken Tree” as very significant. Although in retrospect I suppose it could be considered at least partially prophetic.

My first mentor called me E’lir because I was clever and I knew it. My first real lover called me Dulator because she liked the sound of it. I have been called Shadicar, Lightfinger, and Six-String. I have been called Kvothe the Bloodless, Kvothe the Arcane, and Kvothe the Kingkiller. I have earned those names. Bought and paid for them.

But I was brought up as Kvothe. My father once told me it meant “to know”.

I have, of course, been called many other things. Most of them uncouth, although very few were unearned.

...You may have heard of me. (Rothfuss 53)

These are the introductory words of Kvothe’s story, the secondary story in *The Wind*. First, I will list the names that are never further explained in *The Wind* than they are in this introduction. Firstly, “Maedre,” the name given to him by the Adem, a nation Kvothe will encounter in the second sequel *The Fear of the Wise Man*. Secondly, “Dulator,” “Shadicar,” and “Lightfinger” that are mentioned only on the page 53. Thirdly, “Kingkiller,” “Kvothe the Arcane,” and “Reshi.” Kingkiller and Arcane are

mentioned here and together on the page 45, the former is used as a negative attribute the latter as a positive. However, we may only guess why Kvothe was given the names. We only know that he is in hiding, he never explains why exactly, perhaps he really did kill a king; also he was a member of the Arcanum at the University, and very skilled, but it is not said when people started calling him the Arcane. And then there is *Reshi*, the name only Kvothe's friend Bast uses. It is used throughout the whole primary story and interludes, however it is not even hinted what the name means or why only Bast calls him Reshi. The most that is revealed is that Kvothe does not mind being called Reshi.

Concerning the names that are explained, they appear in the secondary story in the following order: E'lir, Kvothe the Bloodless, Six-String, Re'lar. Let us now discuss the circumstances in which they originated:

E'lir – This name is given to Kvothe twice. First time by his first mentor, Abenthy (Ben), when he is eleven. It means “see-er” as is explained on the page 614. Second time it is given to him rightfully as a title at the University after he proves his accomplishments in “sympathy,” a special kind of magic.

Kvothe the Bloodless – Follows right after the previous, as Kvothe proves his skills in sympathy by unconventional means, harming one of the teachers, and as a result is punished by lashing (Rothfuss 275-7). Beforehand he takes a herbal drug called “nahlrout” that causes him to bleed very little during the lashing. Kvothe explains to Master Arwyl, the physicker (a doctor) why he did this: ““I don't fit in here...they're all watching me, waiting for some sign of weakness.””(Rothfuss 280) He is right of course. He made enemies with the noble Ambrose and now even with one of the Masters. Many people witnessed his lashing and started calling him “Bloodless.”

Six-String – People start calling Kvothe Six-String after his stunning performance in Eolian. One of the strings of his lute breaks during the performance (Rothfuss 369) but he continues playing, proving his exceptional skills as a musician. The performance wins him his talent pipes (Rothfuss 373). The occasion has a great influence on his well-being, as talent pipes will help him to find a job.

Re'lar – This is Kvothe's second title earned at the University. It means, he has now spoken a true name (in his case the name of the wind) (Rothfuss 605, 613), and again, it

is the sign of his progressing skills.

What connects these names is this: they are given to Kvothe on important occasions of his life that leave consequences – both positive (as his progress in the University ranks) and negative (punishment). Also, it is important to note that he gains these names in approximately one year's time and that is highly unusual. It takes usually several terms to become E'lar. Kvothe manages in several days time. To become Re'lar takes more, sometimes years and not all are able to reach this rank. Kvothe becomes one in under a year. Many students dislike him for this reason alone.

This practice of giving names or “re-naming” on an important occasion is similar to Vula's practices, because in cases of “Bloodless” and “six-String,” the history (events) are recorded. Kvothe's new names talk about what happened to him, are reminders of that time, connection of the past and present. They are not motivated based on his appearance, but on these special events.

There are also other names Kvothe bears that he does not mention in his introduction: Kote, Red, Kvothe, son of Arliden. The last he used during his admissions at the University (Rothfuss 236), as he probably does not bear any surname. He himself says his parents “were never officially married”(Rothfuss 54) and not even the first name of his mother is ever mentioned in the first book. There might be several reasons. Either the author does not want to reveal the identity of Kvothe's ancestors yet, as Kvothe's mother was a noble (Rothfuss 54) and it could influence the story, or the subject is too personal for Kvothe to say to others, or Kvothe does not want to reveal it yet. The name Red is motivated, based on the red colour of his hair, as is his name “the Flame,” one of the meanings of “Maedre.” And lastly, there is Kote, the name he bears as an innkeeper, the first name that is used to refer to him in the primary story. It is never explicitly said what the name means, only that “[h]e had chosen the name carefully when he came to this place,”(Rothfuss 10) where “this place” refers to Newarre. So let us look whether the name Kote could be motivated.

There appears a word “Kote” in the text on the page 455: Master Kilvin, the University teacher, is “Cealdish” (i.e. one of the nationalities in the book), and his mother tongue is called “Siaru.” There is a fire at the University and after the accident he tells Kvothe:

“‘*Chan Vaen edan Kote*’”(Rothfuss 455). Kvothe tries to translate: “‘Seven years ... I don’t know *Kote*.’”(Rothfuss 455) Kilvin explains that it is an old saying in Siaru and means: “Expect disaster every seven years”(Rothfuss 456). *Kote* probably translates as a “disaster,” but it is never explicitly stated. However if the word “chan” has the same root as “chaen” from Temic language, chaen meaning seven (Rothfuss 82), then there are left only two capitalized nouns – year and disaster, if the phrase translates literally. Calling himself *Kote*, Disaster, could be considered motivated choice based on Kvothe’s present view of his life, present meaning the time in the primary story when he is around twenty four. Kvothe never says that he is unhappy or that he pities his life and regrets his actions, however his closest friend Bast is worried and that is the reason he calls Chronicler to collect Kvothe’s story. He talks to him about Kvothe:

“We’re tucked away so safe and sound that he’s practically fading into the woodwork...And it’s a damn sight more than a bad mood...This place is killing him...People saw him as a hero, and he played the part...It became the truth...Now he sees *himself* as an innkeeper, and a failed innkeeper at that.”(Rothfuss 657-8).

In the prologue, Kvothe is described as “a man who is waiting to die”(Rothfuss 1). He, seeing himself as a disaster, settled in Newarre, almost sounding as “nowhere.” If the meaning of *Kote* really is “disaster,” then the name implies that Kvothe views his life, and himself, as a failure. It would explain the silence, the emptiness that starts and ends the story, the prologue and epilogue, both named “A Silence of Three Parts.” The other Kvothe’s names that are used and explained in the story are a contrast to the *Kote*. They speak of his time as a young and skilled hero, Kvothe the Bloodless, Six-String, Re’lar under a year. All of them together, are Kvothe, the name encompasses all his sides, bright and dark. As Chronicler and his attitude towards Kvothe indicates: “‘Then again,’ he made a gesture as if to show how useless words were. ‘You are Kvothe.’”(Rothfuss 48). No words can describe him better than his own name.

Conclusion

The Name of the Wind offers a great variety of names and that is one of the main reasons the novel was chosen as a source for analysis. There are layers to the meaning of names, implications that contribute to the story, making it whole. Moreover, the names, true names are an inseparable part of the fictional world Rothfuss create, and breathe into the story the magical, the otherworldly.

I separated the names in the novel into six categories according to their function to better understand the implications a name is able to carry. The categories are organised from those with the names that are the least prominent in the novel, to those that are the most prominent and powerful.

The first category features the “names of credibility.” Being in the background of the novel, these names help create a substantial, believable world. Tropes are common in this category, often creating humorous or memorable names.

The second is the category titled “names of social standing.” Here belong titles, and ranks; if a name of a character is accompanied by a title, it often implies what behavioural patterns will the character display, relying of the stereotypes presented in the book.

The third introduced category is “names of quality.” In here appear all names that carry an attributive value, be it a proper name or a name of a place. They are often context-dependent, created by the author, and some of them are powerful enough to change the flow of story when they appear.

The fourth category “I am here names,” encompasses names of secondary characters and it is as diverse as the characters themselves. These names may reveal information about their bearer connected to their background, education, profession, life-style, even the appearance, as many of them are motivated.

The fifth category is “names of special meaning.” Here belong true names and names that influence the plot. True names in Rothfuss’ world are non-arbitrary, the name is the thing itself, therefore they are very powerful, but also hard to learn. Many names are

accompanied by power as well as fear and prejudice.

The last category of “I am legendary” names is small in numbers but significant for the story. It carries the names of the protagonist and the antagonist who bear multiple names and their implications stretch throughout the whole novel. It is clear the names were chosen with the utmost care, perfectly capturing the personality and also the life of their bearer. When we understand the meaning of these names, we can understand the characters better than we would if they were described just in words.

Hopefully, these categories can help shed some light on the treatment of names in *The Name of the Wind*, and express the importance of names in the story as names are a source of information for the reader.

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